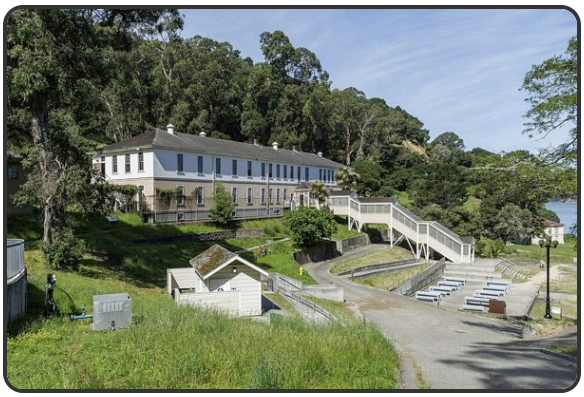
🗽 Immigration & Cities: Reading

US History · Unit 3 · Level 2 (modified) · our own reading

Name: _____

Words to know: ***detain*** *= to hold someone and not let them leave ·* ***interrogation*** *= a long set of questions*



Detention barracks, Angel Island Immigration Station

Angel Island: The Immigration Station in the West

Angel Island sits in San Francisco Bay, California. From 1910 to 1940 it was an **immigration station**, a place where newcomers were checked before entering the U.S. It is sometimes called the “Ellis Island of the West,” but it was very different.

Most people held at Angel Island came from **China**. A law from 1882, the **Chinese Exclusion Act**, stopped most Chinese workers from coming. Only some people, like merchants, students and children of U.S. citizens, were allowed in.

In 1906 an earthquake and fire in San Francisco destroyed many birth records. Some Chinese immigrants then came with papers saying they were the children of citizens. They were called **“paper sons”** and **“paper daughters.”**

To catch them, officers asked long **interrogations** (questions). How many steps lead to your front door? Where is the rice kept? A relative was asked the same questions. If the answers did not match, the person could be sent back.

At Ellis Island most people were done in hours. At Angel Island, many people were **detained** (held) for weeks or months, some for two years. The rooms were crowded and locked.

Some detainees carved **poems** in Chinese into the wooden walls. More than 200 poems survive. They tell about missing family, anger at unfair treatment, and hope for a new life.

A fire closed the station in 1940. The Exclusion Act ended in 1943. Today Angel Island is a state park and museum, and the poems are protected.

Check your reading

1. Which law kept most Chinese workers out of the U.S.?

A. the Homestead Act

B. the 19th Amendment

C. the Chinese Exclusion Act

2. Who were “paper sons”?

A. immigrants with papers saying they were children of citizens

B. newspaper boys

C. workers who made paper

3. How was Angel Island different from Ellis Island?

A. It was in New York

B. Nobody was questioned

C. People were held much longer

4. What do the wall poems tell us?